

What Am I Making?

aka The Ontology of Art

Session 2:

The Continental/Critical Lens



Philosophy of Art with Rebecca Millsop, Ph.D.

ARTIST COMMONS

How This Works

- Not a traditional philosophy class
- No argument analysis, no debating which theory is correct

The Goal:

1. Know the major theories – understand what they claim
2. Use them as tools – apply them to your own practice

Format:

- Talk + Reflection Questions + Q&A at the end
- Drop questions in the chat as we go
- Post follow ups on Mighty Network - I'll engage there!

The Four Questions

Q1: What am I making?

"I make stuff but is it art?" →
"Here's what makes my work art and why."

Philosophical territory:
ontology and definition

Q2: How does it mean?

"I hope people understand it..." →
"Here's how my art creates meaning."

Philosophical territory:
semiotics and communication

Q3: Where do I fit?

"Everything has already been done!" →
"Here is my lineage & my contribution."

Philosophical territory:
originality and authorship

Q4: Why does it matter?

"Is my work saying anything important?" →
"Here is why my work matters."

Philosophical territory:
value and function

Two Philosophical Traditions

Analytic Philosophy

Emphasis on precise definitions, logical analysis, clear arguments.

What is X?

Trying to find the boundaries of a category.

Continental Philosophy

Emphasis on lived experience, historical context, how things actually show up for us.

What does X do?

What's at stake when we use a category?

Last Session: How to **define** art
Today: What art **does**

Definitions → Functions

Four Frameworks

1. Art as reproducible object 
2. Art as truth-event 
3. Art as autonomous practice 
4. Art as reorganization of perception 

Reproduction made it politics.



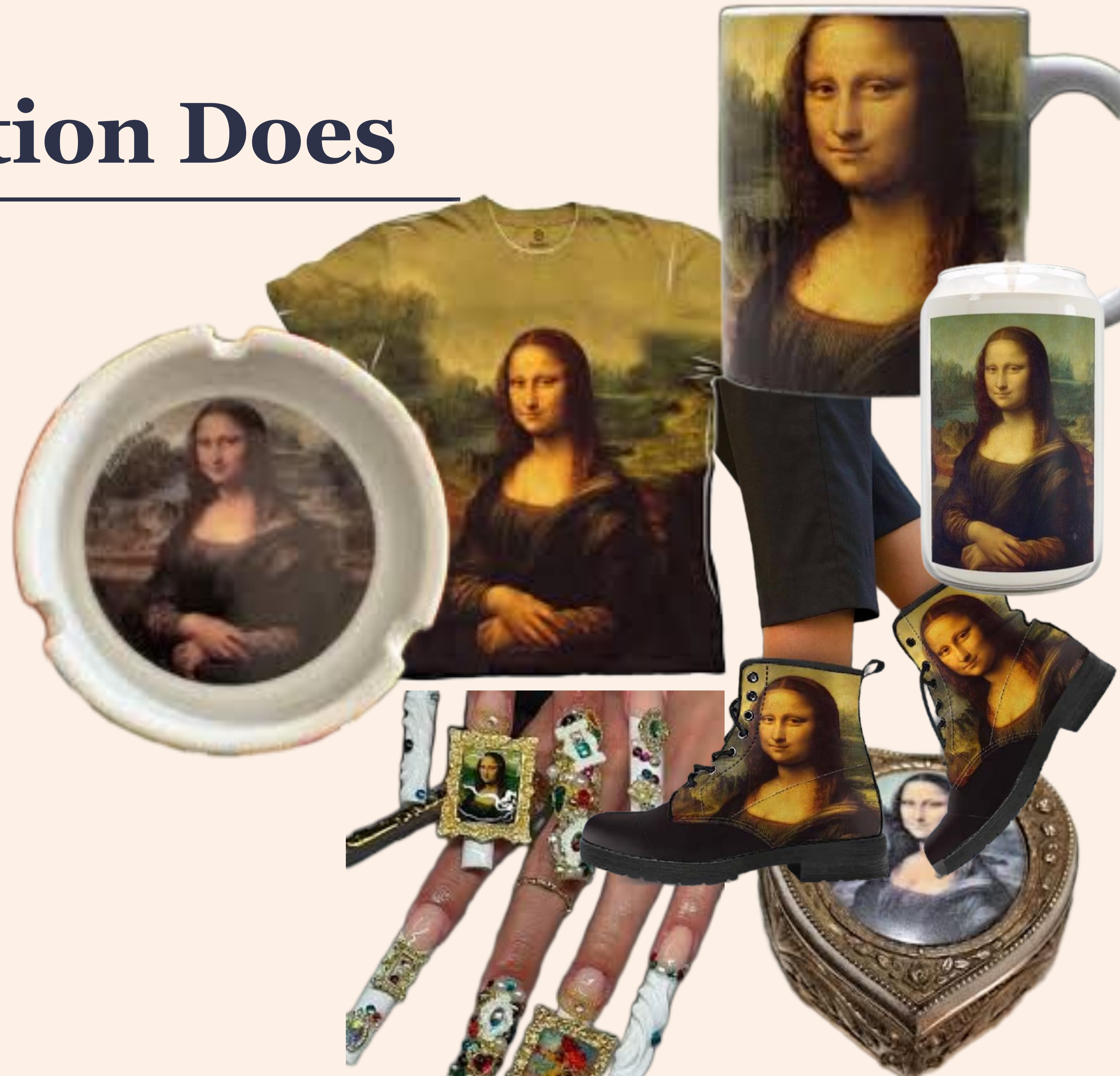
Aura

The unique presence of the
artwork in time and space.



What Reproduction Does

- Photography & film create perfect copies.
- The copy travels.
The original stays.
- Benjamin: This is progressive.



Two Paths After Aura

- **Art for art's sake** → tries to recreate aura (reactionary)
- **Politicized art** → embraces reproduction (progressive)



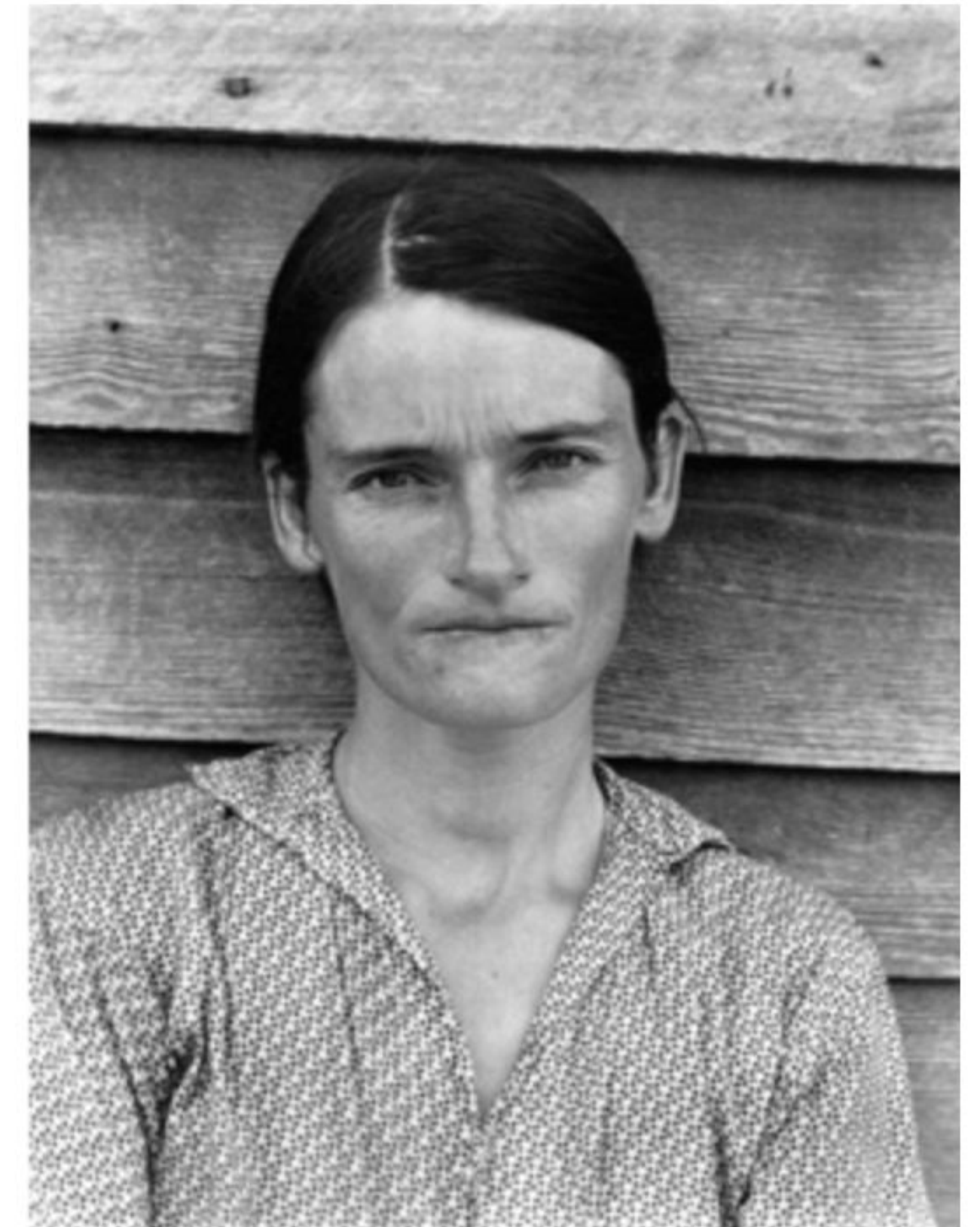
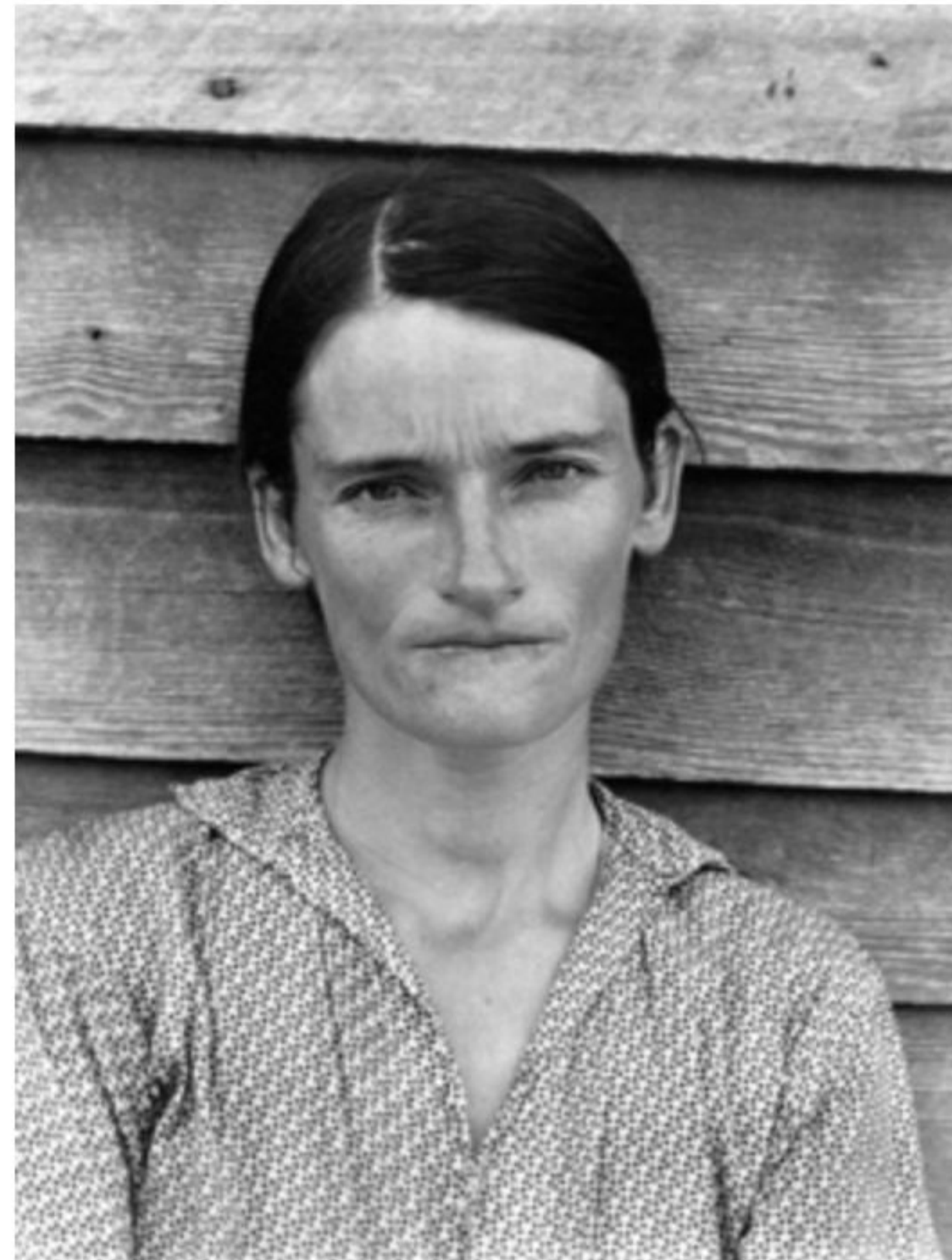
Is the binary really that clean?



Where It Breaks Down



Sherrie Levine



Left: Walker Evans, *Alabama Tenant Farmer Wife*, 1936, gelatin silver print, 20.9 x 14.4 cm, (The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York); right: Sherrie Levine, *After Walker Evans*, gelatin silver print, 12.8 x 9.8 cm (The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York)

Trevor Paglen



They Took the Faces from the Accused and the Dead, 2019



For your practice...

Takeaway Question

Does your work have aura? If yes, where does it live – the object, a space, the viewer, or somewhere else?

If it does not have aura, what work does it do in the world?

Framework 2

Art as Truth-Event

aletheia = truth =
unconcealment

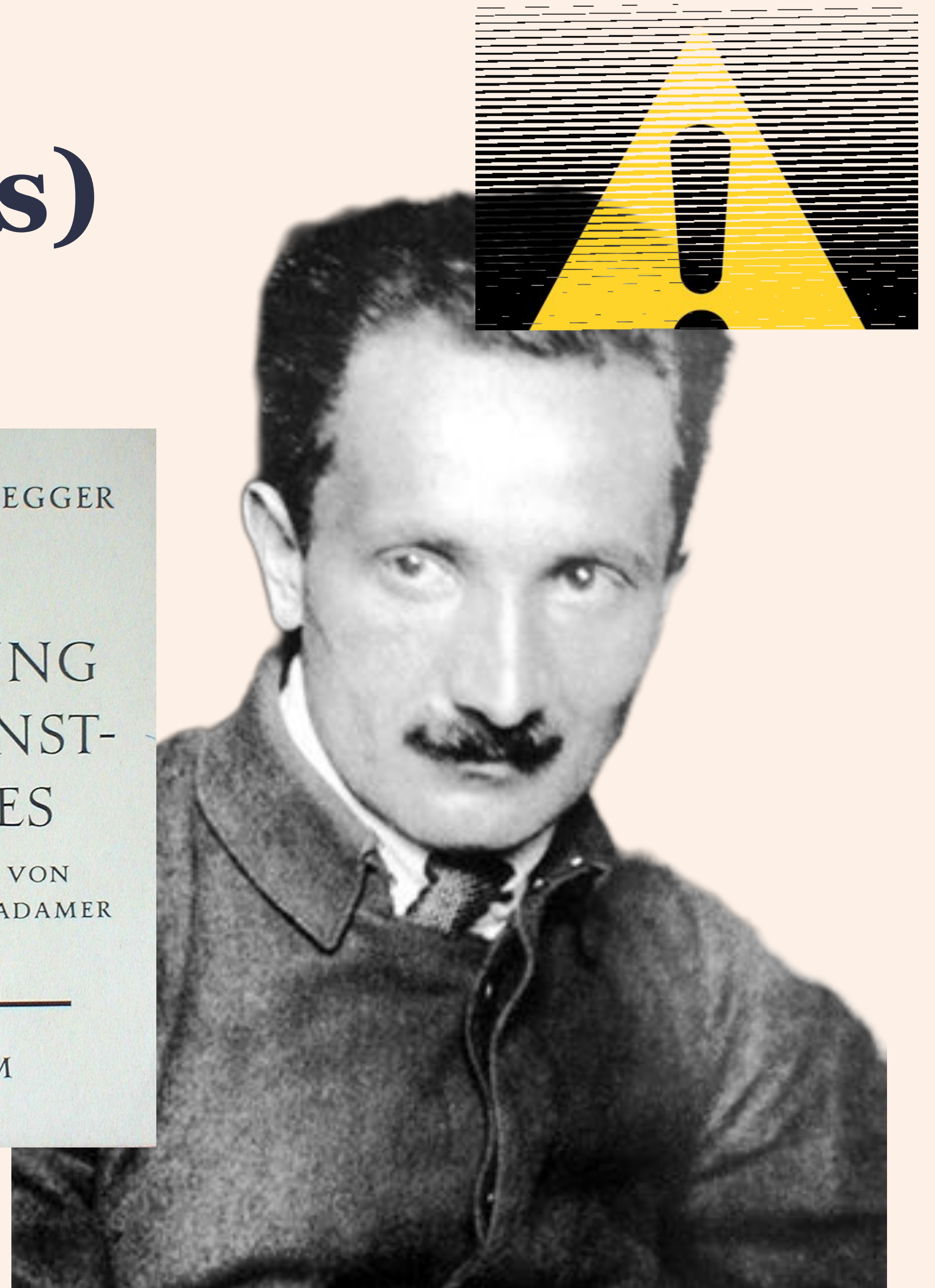
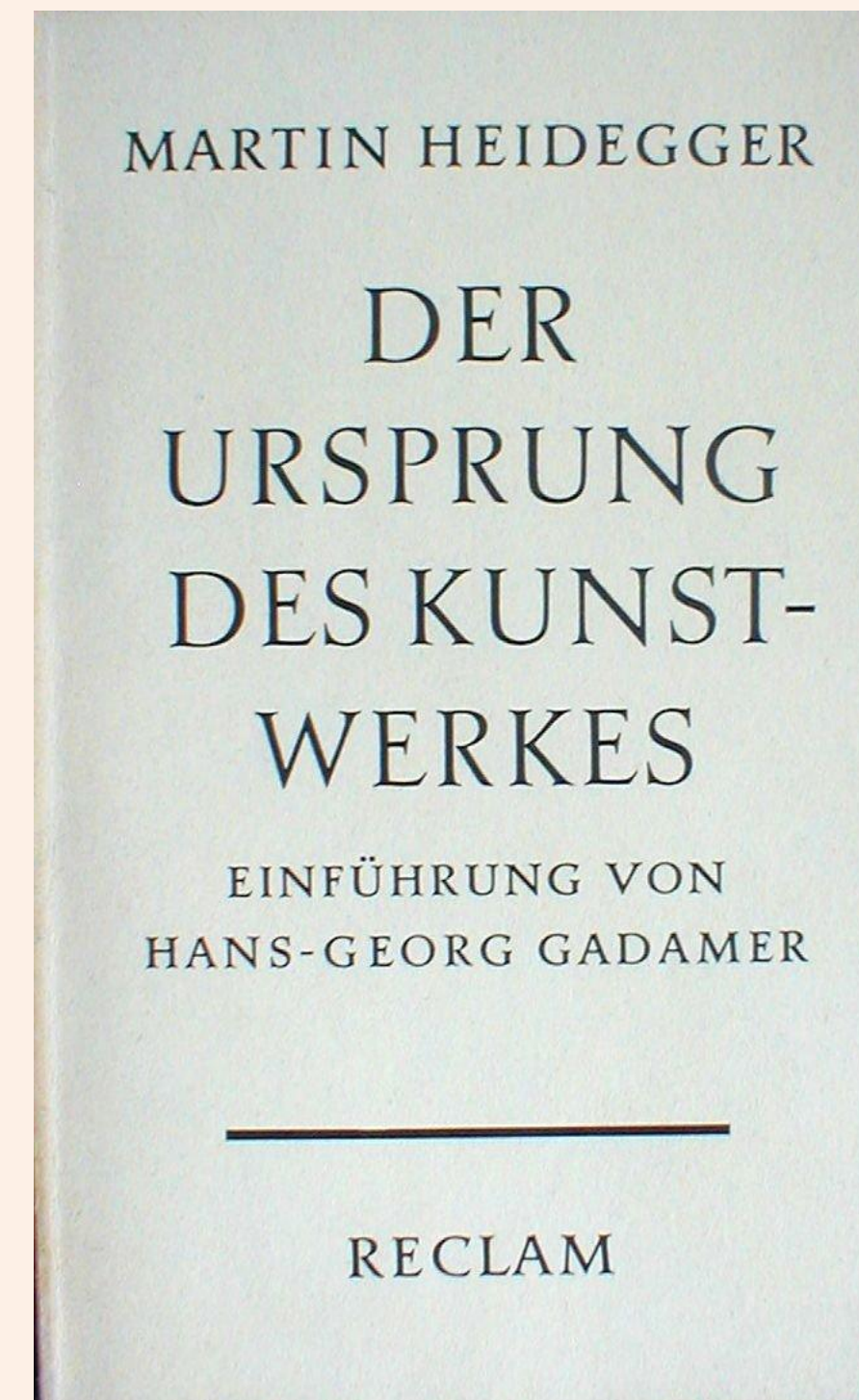
art = where truth **happens**



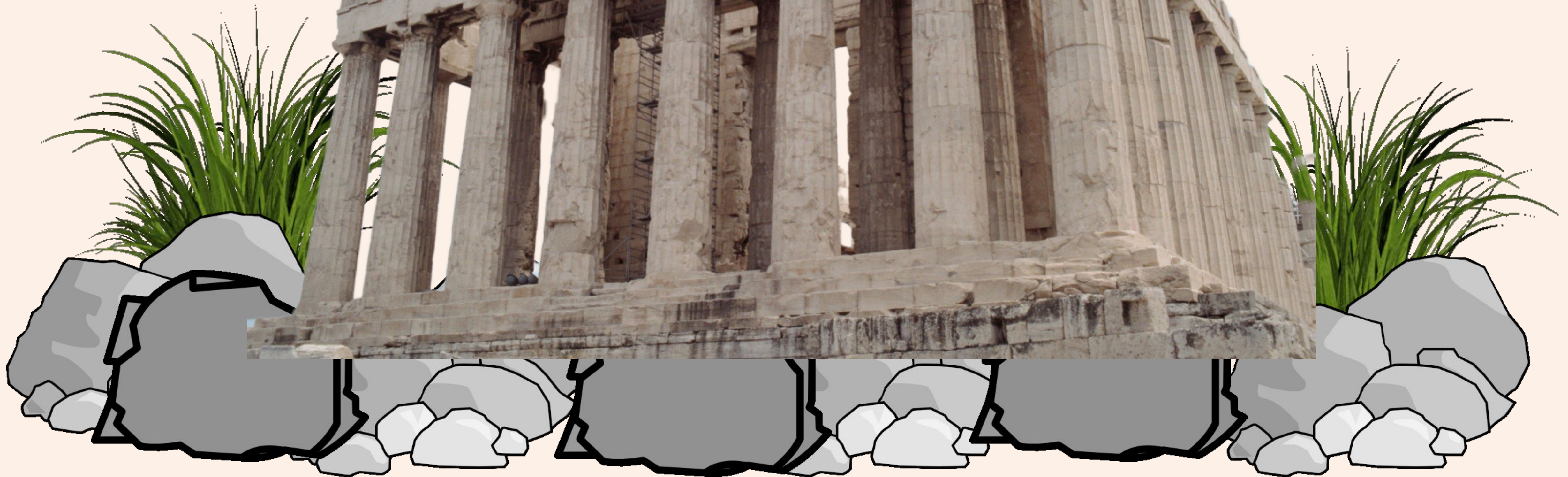
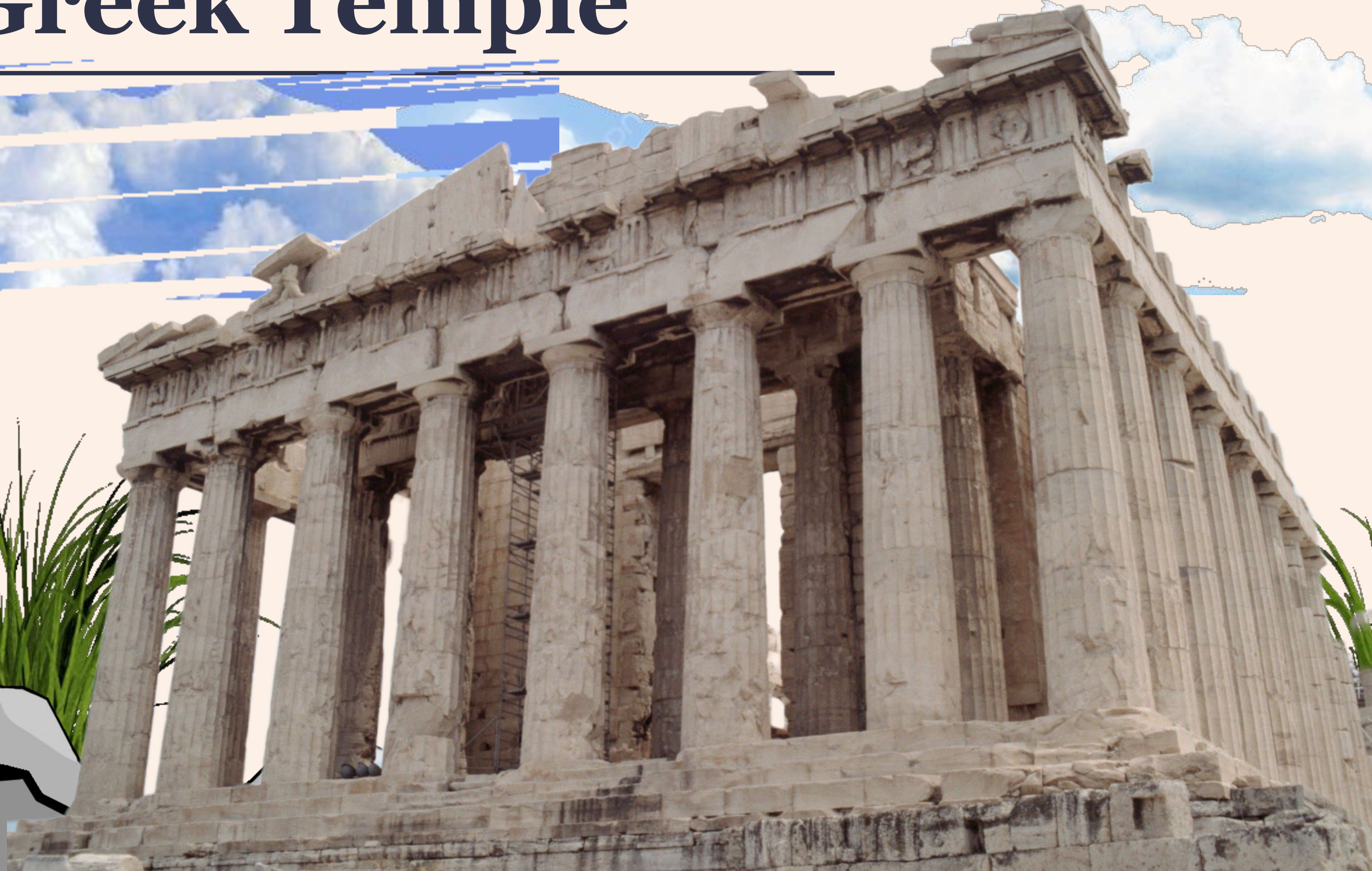
Martin Heidegger (1930s)

Art doesn't come from
an artist's skill or
creativity...

*Art comes from truth
happening.*



The Greek Temple



Alva Noë (2015)

Art as “strange tool”

Art takes our organized activities and puts them on display.

STRANGE
TOOLS

*ART and
HUMAN
NATURE*

ALVA NOË

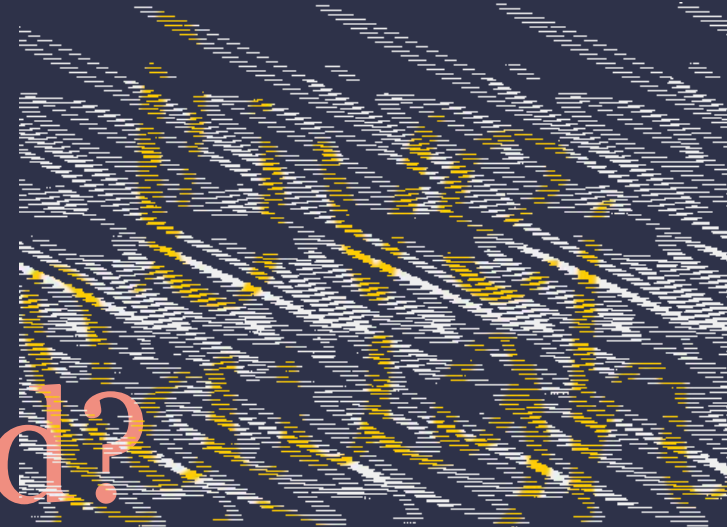


Why This Differs

- *Plato/Aristotle*: Art **imitates** the world 
- *Formalists*: Art **creates** aesthetic experience 
- *Institutional Theory*: Art is what institutions **recognize** 
- *Open Concept*: Art is **family resemblance** and **innovation** 
- *Benjamin*: Technology changes what art is, from aura to political 
- *Heidegger*: Art **discloses** - it makes visible what wasn't visible 

Where It Breaks Down

1. Everything is profound?



OCT.19.1966

2. Privileges phenomenological, immersive and experiential. Conceptual art?



3. Can you separate the philosophy from the philosopher?



9.1966

James Turrell



Leading, Turrell's 94th skyspace.



Anicka Yi



In Love with the World, Tate Modern, 2021.



For your practice...

Takeaway Question

Think about one piece you've made...

- What does it **unconceal** about the nature of something?
- What organized activity does your work put on display? What does your audience do automatically that your work interrupts?

Framework 3

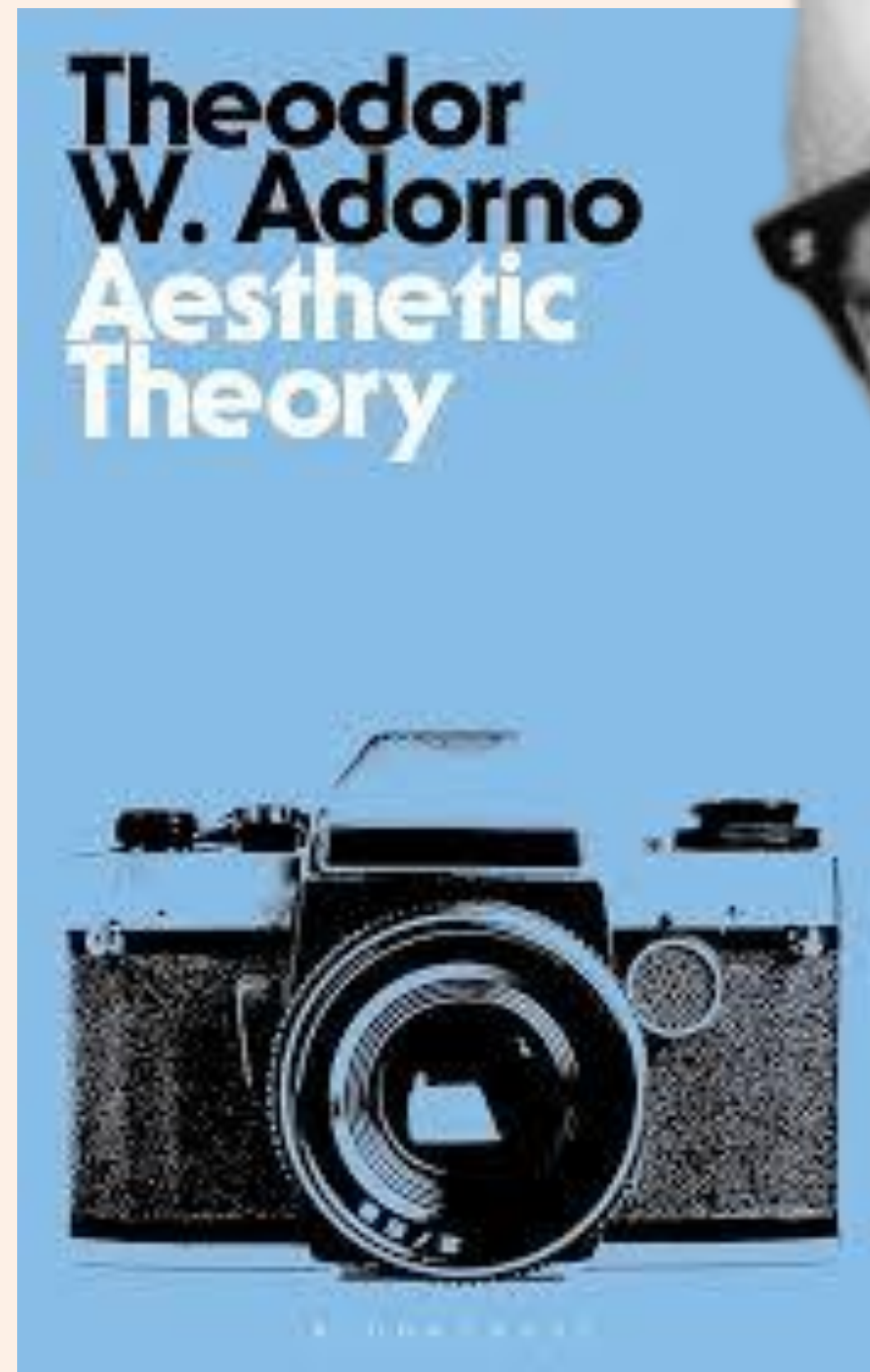
Art as Autonomous Practice

Art
=
Refusal



Theodor Adorno (1970)

*Art serves
society best by
NOT serving it.*



Real art **resists** commodification

Resists by being *difficult*, by *refusing easy pleasure*.

Autonomous art > explicitly political art
because it refuses the **logic** of capitalism entirely

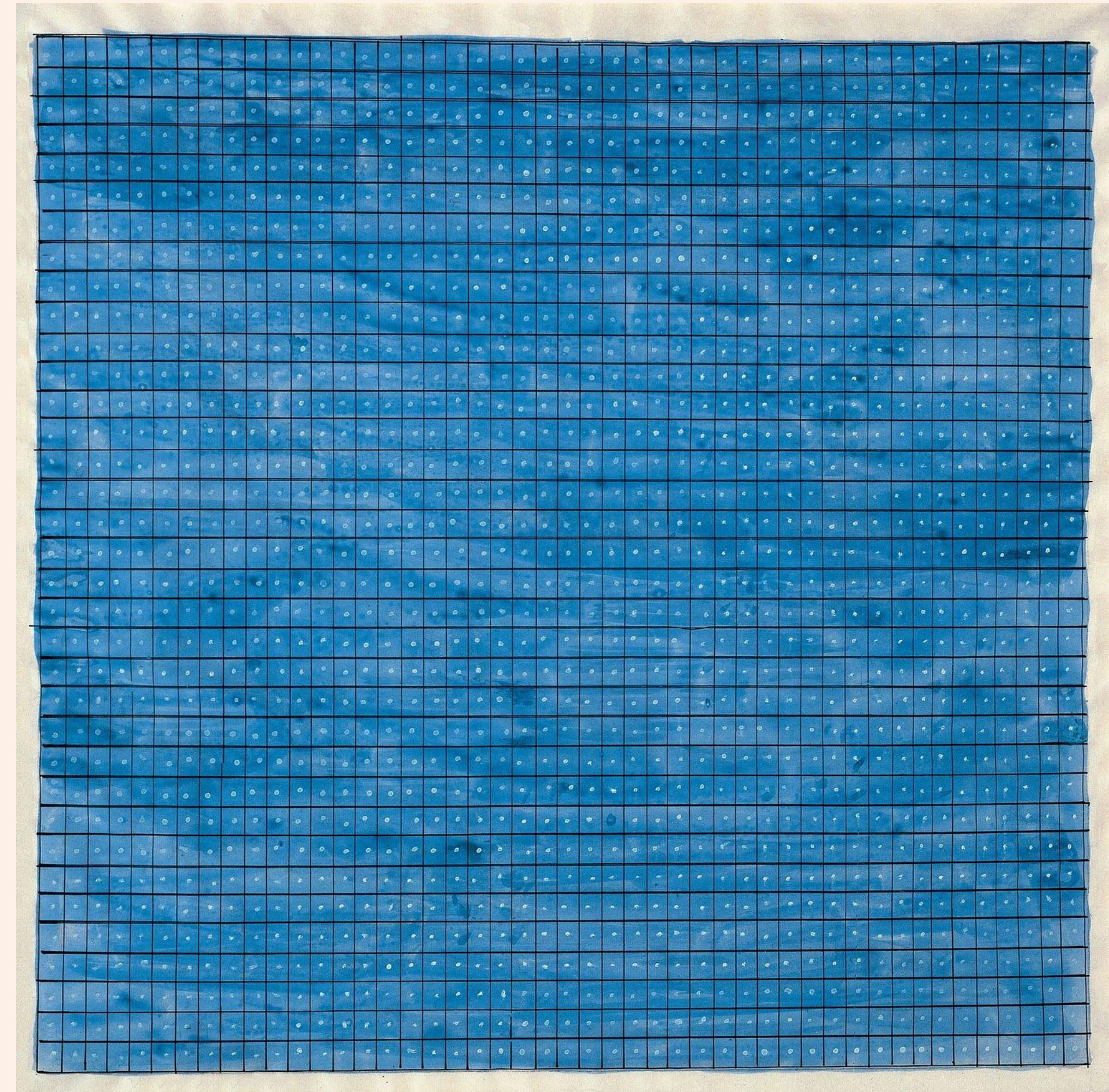
Schoenberg vs. Jazz

- Schoenberg: difficult, atonal → resists consumption ✓
- Jazz: accessible, pleasurable → fits the culture industry ✗

*Adorno was really,
really wrong about jazz.*



The Paradox



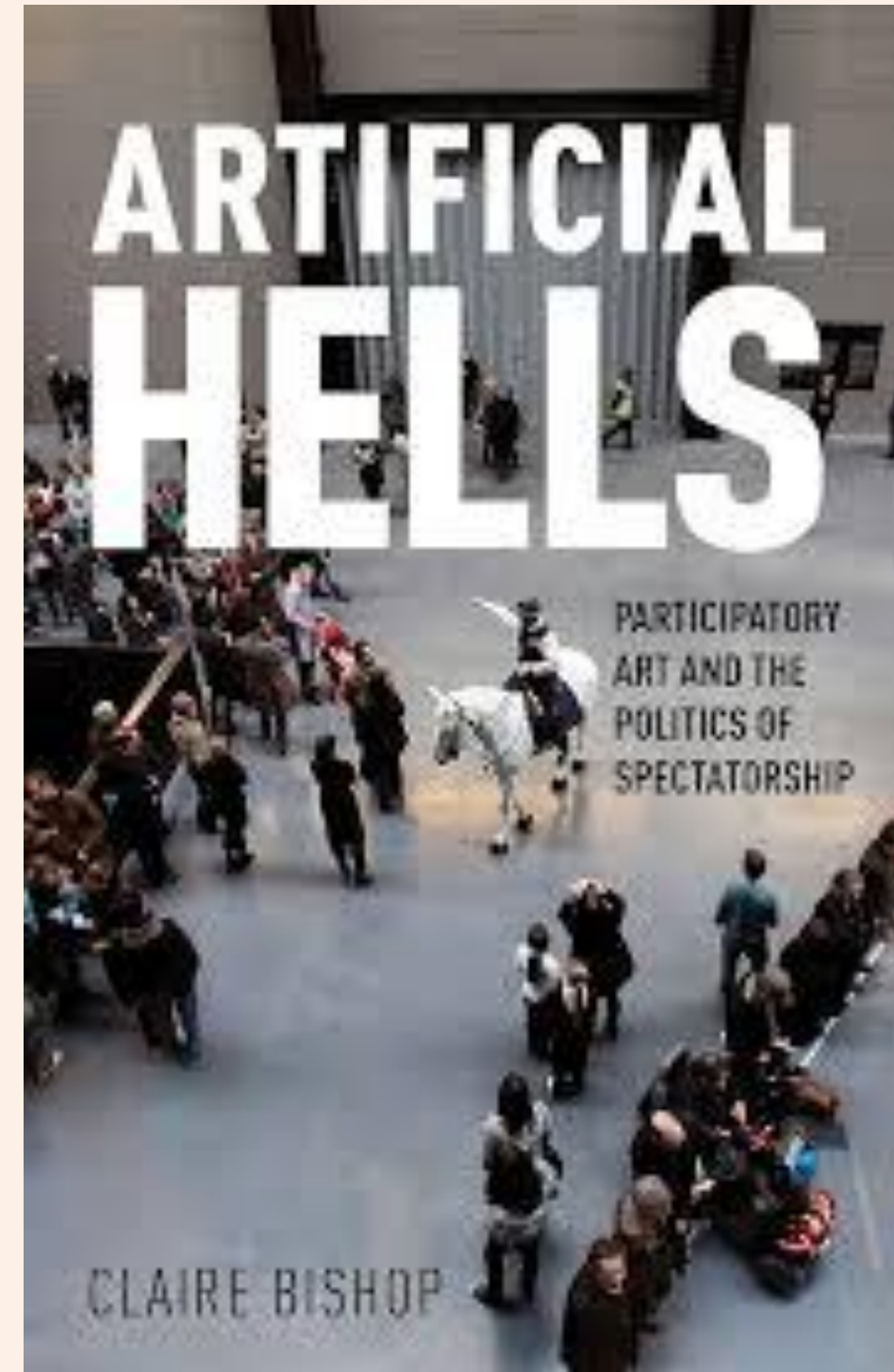
Where It Breaks Down

1. The Dead End
2. The eurocentrism problem
3. Accessible ≠ Absorbed



Claire Bishop (2012)

- Participatory art isn't *automatically* political
- Community ≠ criticality
- If everyone leaves feeling good... did the art *do anything*?



Santiago Sierra



250 cm Line Tattooed on 6 Paid People, 1999



Theaster Gates



Stony Island Arts Bank



For your practice...

Takeaway Question

Where does your work fall on the spectrum between autonomous and instrumental?

Is that where you WANT it to be?

Framework 4

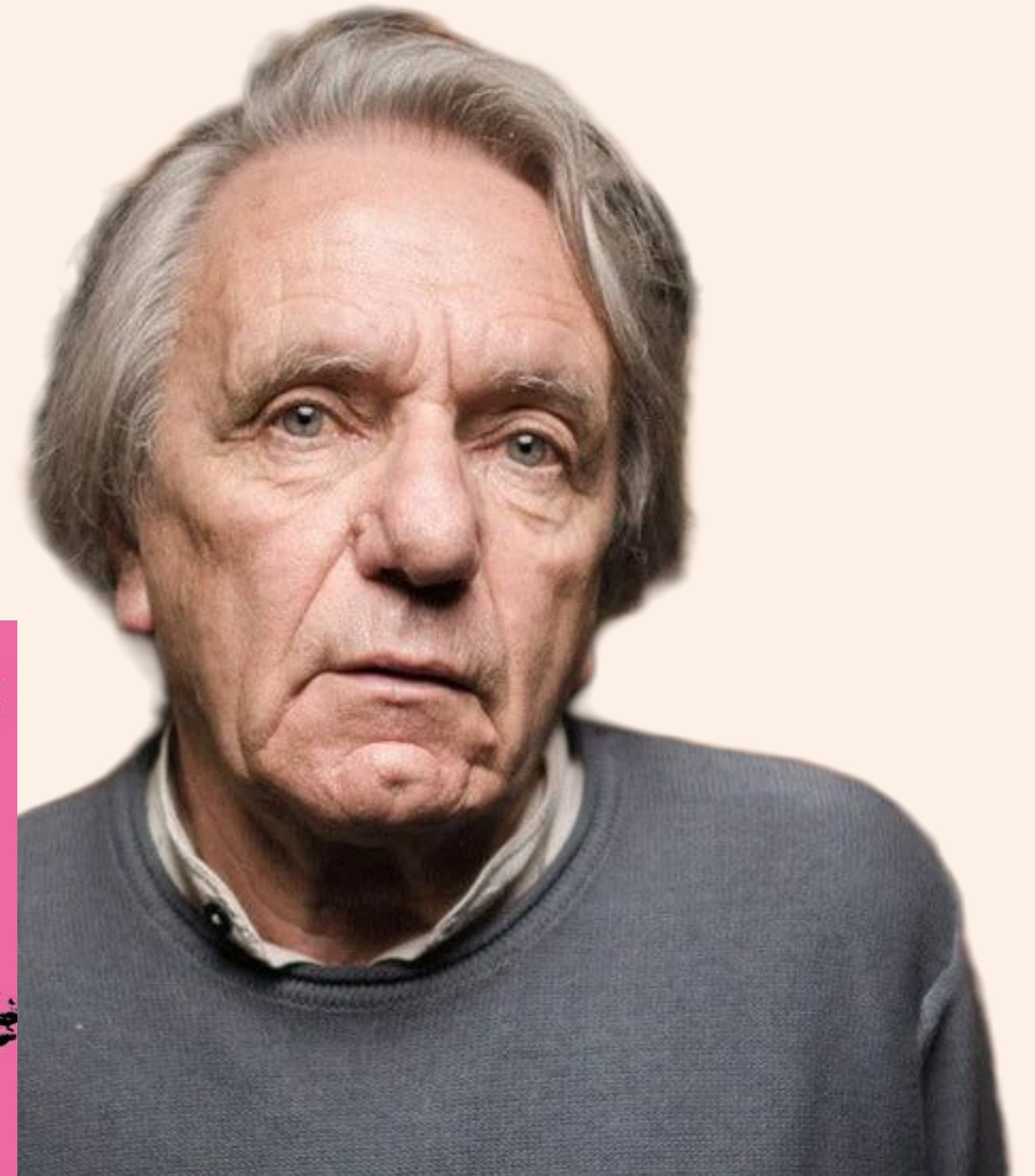
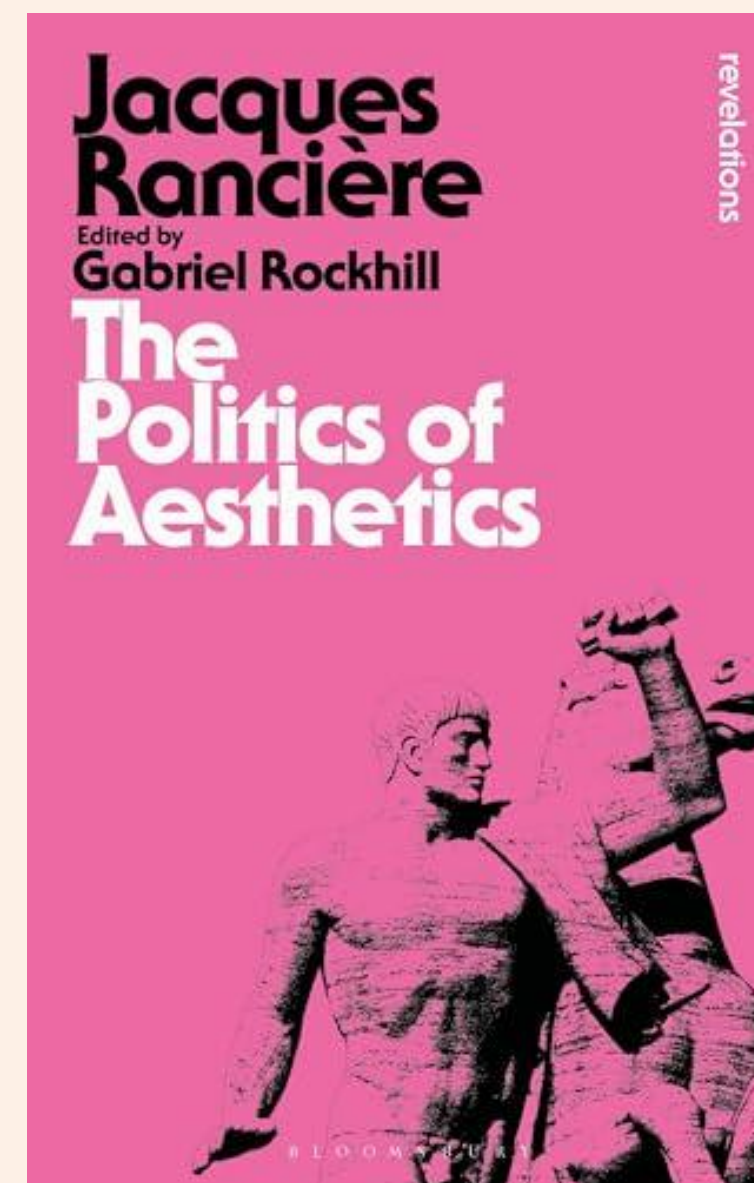
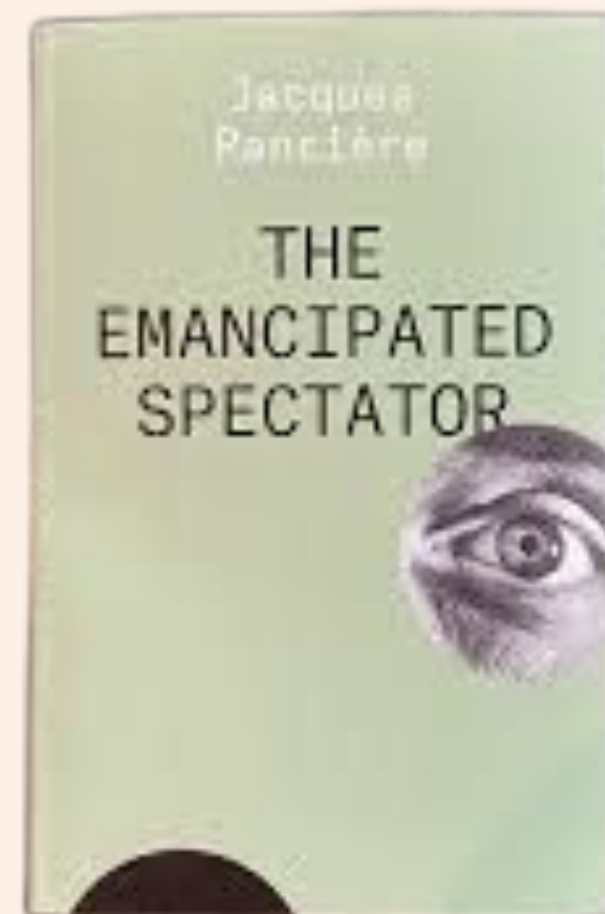
Art as Reorganization of Perception

Art
=
Whatever redistributes
the sensible

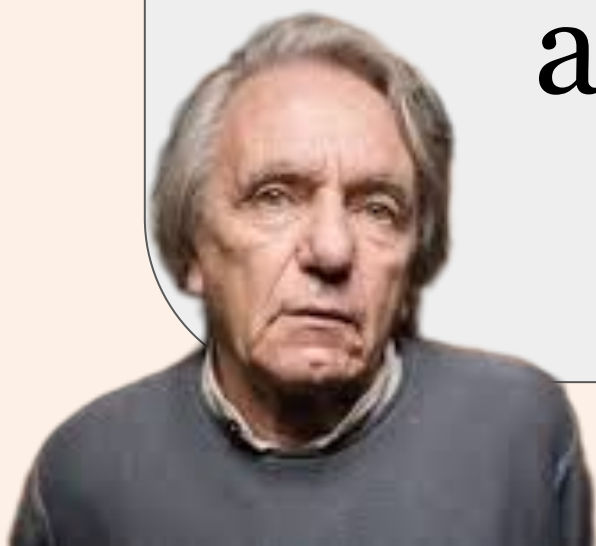


Jacques Rancière

*Art is whatever **redistributes the sensible**. It reorganizes what can be seen, heard, said, and thought.*



Why is a peasant's shoe a worthy subject for painting at all?



What does this reveal about the **nature** of these shoes?



Art's Politics Through Form

- Art redistributes the sensible.
- Not through message or content.
- Through formal operations – how it organizes *perception*.
- Art is political **because** it reconfigures what's visible and sayable.

Form is the mechanism, not the end.

The Aesthetic Regime



Where It Breaks Down

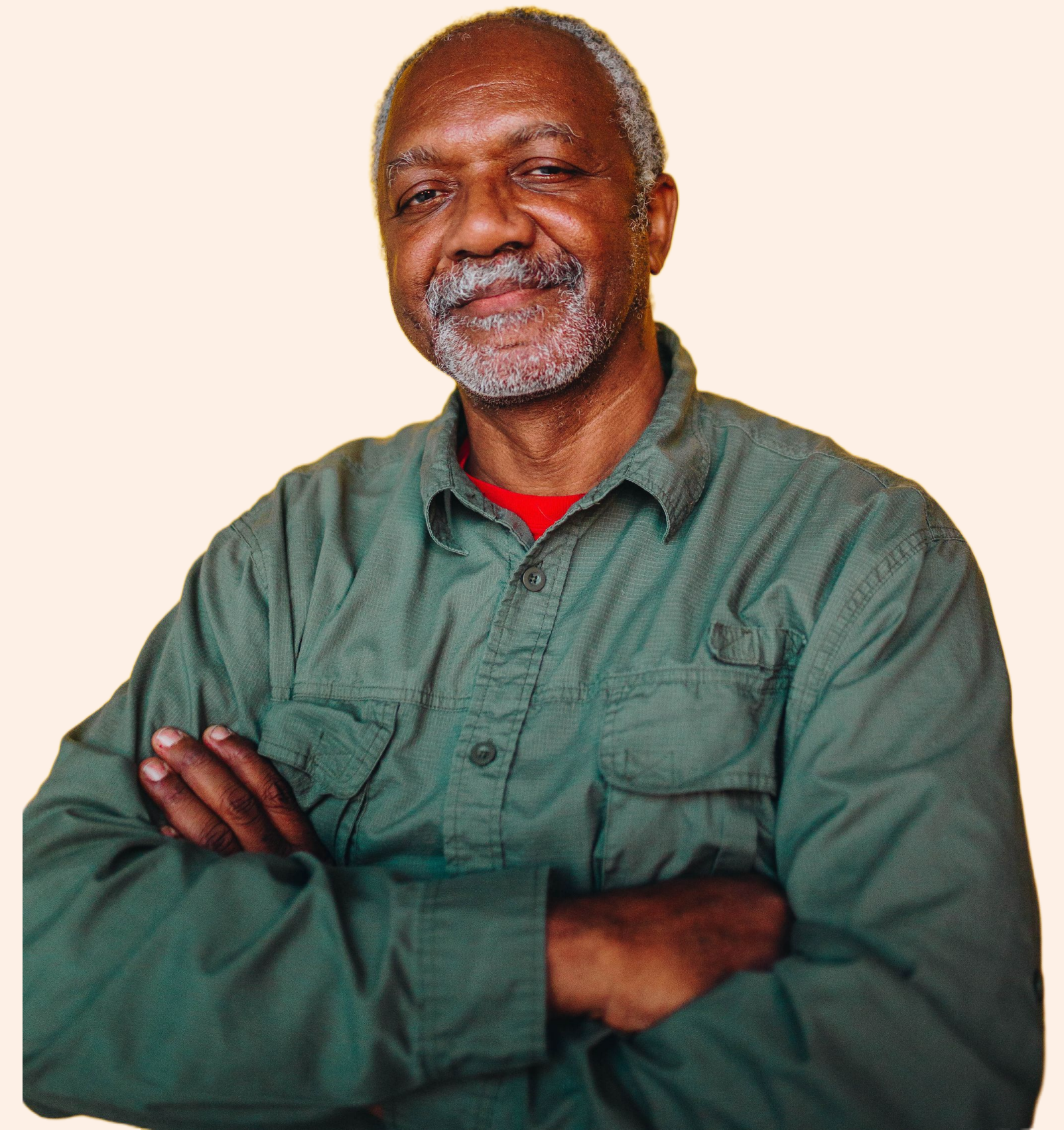
1. Too permissive?
2. Redistribution as a formula



Kerry James Marshall



Our Town, 1995.



Torkwase Dyson



Way Over There Inside Me (A Festival of Inches), 2023, installation view.



Forensic Architecture



Saydnaya Prison, Syria. 2016



Grenfell Tower, London. 2017.

For your practice...

Takeaway Question

What does your work make visible, audible, or sayable that wasn't before?

How does your work redistribute the sensible?

Four Frameworks

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Session 1a: How to **define** art (analytic)

Session 1b: What art **does** (continental)

**Philosophical depth behind your answer
to 'what am I making?'**

Up Next in Q2!

How does it *mean*?

Questions?
Thoughts?
All welcome!

Thank You So Much!

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